



flowered as a center of commerce and culture. In 1824, the bloody conflict that liberated Peru from Spain was fought here, and remembered as the Battle of Ayacucho. Again during the 1980s, the people were

caught up in violence between the army and terrorists rebelling against it. Today though, the warmth of the Ayacucho people, together with their exquisite craft skills, have made their home a hugely popular visitor attraction.

COLORFUL SCENES

The Ayacucho are known for producing *retablos*, painted wooden boxes framing papier mâché scenes—religious or historical. This simple one shows a Palm Sunday gathering, but some are very complex, with several stories like a house.



MAKING MERRY

In Ayacucho, February is carnival time, when the streets overflow with dancers, singers, musicians, and high-spirited revelers. Here, a brilliantly costumed troupe of players (note the glowering devil on the left) makes its leisurely way through the crowd.

SOLID HERITAGE

Many of the city's important buildings were constructed using rose-colored stone, quarried locally, which is called the "marble of Peru." The structure that dominates this cityscape is the Town Hall.

MODERN INFLUENCES

Ayacucho people in urban areas enjoy wearing traditional dress on special occasions. Many of them, however—especially children—prefer modern clothing for every day.

